



2.6 Malthusian Theory

Objective and Essential Learning

2.6 Explain theories of population growth & decline.

- Malthusian theory and its critiques are used to analyze population change and its consequences.

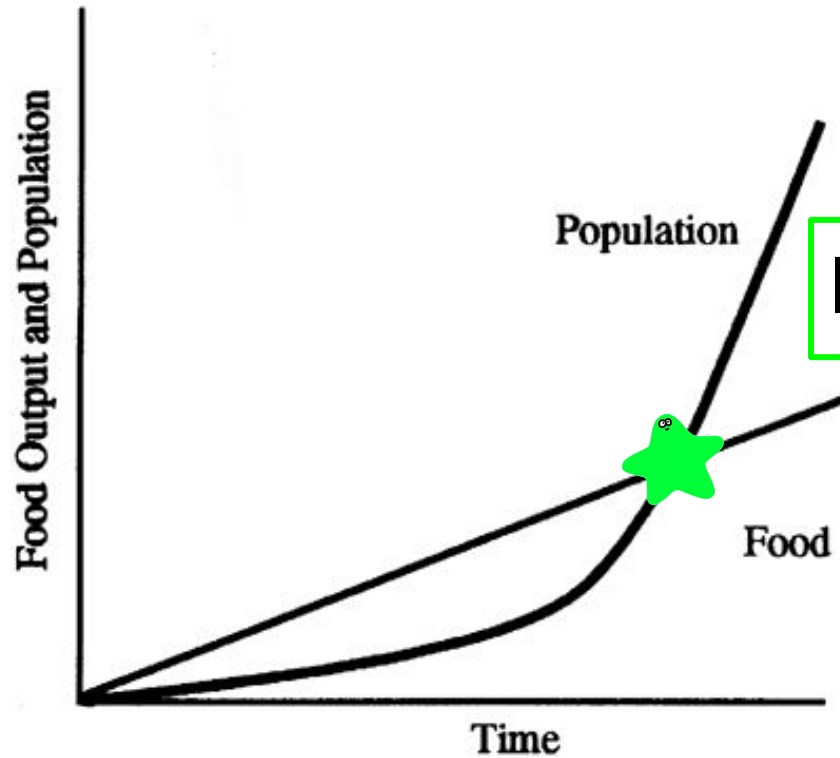


Malthusian Theory

- **Carrying Capacity:** The amount of population that a location can support without harming the environment.
 - Geographers way of saying "overpopulation"
- **Thomas Malthus**
 - Lived in England in the 1700s.
 - Experienced the Industrial Revolution.
 - Rising life expectancy, lower death rates
 - 1798 published *An Essay on the Principles of Population Growth*



Malthusian Theory



Malthusian Theory

Malthus' Claim:

- Population grows exponentially while food output only grow arithmetically. This would result in a food shortage and famine due to overpopulation.
 - Exponentially: 2, 4, 8, 16
 - Arithmetically: 1, 2, 3, 4

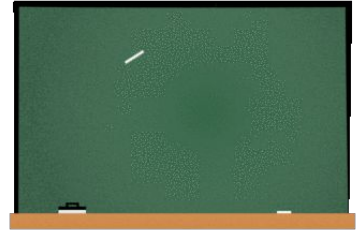
A population boom: exists
Thomas Malthus:



Criticisms of Malthusian Theory

1. Factors that have slowed population growth:

- Contraceptives
- Education and advancement of women



2. Factors that have increased the efficiency of farming:

- Mechanized Farming
- Hybrid Seeds
- Chemical Fertilizers



Criticisms of Malthusian Theory

3. New Technologies and Inventions:

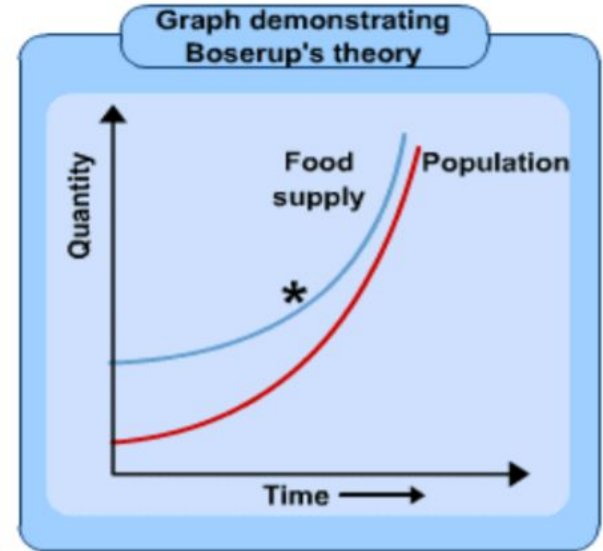
- More efficient travel to deliver food to a wider range of consumers without spoiling.
- Refrigeration in trucks and railcars as well as homes to preserve food.
- Tin Cans to preserve food for longer time periods.



Boserup's Theory

Boserup's Claim

- Food supply is impacted directly by population growth. As population increases humans will develop new technologies to also increase production of food supply.



Neo-Malthusians

Neo = new

- Concerns about sustainable use of the environment – the earth's resources cannot only sustain a finite (limited) population.
 - Decreasing birth rates in developed countries
 - Strain on natural resources
 - Water insecurity, Desertification, pollution of air and water, etc.
 - Overconsumption
 - Famine & Starvation



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